

ECON 490: *Course Overview*

Email: tmackay@fullerton.edu

Plan for Today

Class introductions

Talk about:

- Course structure
- Assignments
- Doing well in this class

Finish with a review of basic statistics and introduction to R

About Me

My name is Taylor

- I got a PhD in Economics from UCI in 2022
- I also did an MA in econ at SDSU
- I do applied micro-style research on housing, poverty, and immigration

5th year at CSUF, 7th time teaching this class

Class Introductions

No ice breakers or fun facts about yourself

Instead, let's do the following:

- Complete a quick survey online

For the survey, scan QR code on the right

- Use your CSUF login
- URL is also on Canvas



Course Prerequisites

To enroll in ECON 490, you need to have taken:

- All of ECON 310, ECON 325, and ECON 340
- At least *one* of ECON 440, ISDS 361B, or a 400-level Economics elective

If you have a permit from Hugh and me to waive one of these, you are all set

- If you do not have a permit/permission, however, please speak to me **ASAP**

Expectations for this Course

This class is important because it is required for you to graduate

- I expect you to treat this class, and your graduation, seriously
- This means showing up to class and being responsible for your performance

After today, I expect you to be aware of all course requirements from the syllabus

It is your responsibility to:

- Show up to class
- Review all course material each week
- Carefully review all assignment requirements and ask questions *in advance*

Assignments for this Class

<i>Category</i>	<i>Percentage of Final Grade</i>
Capstone Project	40%
In-Class Activities	40%
Attendance	20%

The R coding activities are ***not graded***, but they are strongly recommended and can be submitted via Canvas for feedback

Classroom Technology Policy

No laptops, tablets, or phones during the lecture portion of class

Devices should be closed and put away

Printed lecture handouts are provided for every lecture

- You do not need a laptop, tablet, or phone to follow along or take notes
- Devices are welcome during in-class activities, coding activities, the capstone data lab, and the break

Using a device during lecture costs your ***attendance credit*** for that week

Doing Well in this Class

Philosophy I've adopted for this course—*move as much graded work as possible into an in-person format and reduce out of class assignments*

You should:

- Show up to class
- Submit assignments on time
- Carefully review lecture material and (limited) assigned reading

In-Class Activities

We have weekly graded in-class activities worth 40% of your final grade

- Usually a 1-2 page quiz at the start of class, or an R coding activity
- On presentation weeks (weeks 11, 14, 15), uploading your slides on time and attending class earns full credit

Guidelines:

- You must complete activities during the class in which they are assigned
- Excused absences can make up assignments for full credit within 1 week
- Your lowest in-class activity score will be dropped (i.e., excused absence)
 - One exception: Week 8 CPS data lab, which cannot be dropped

Attendance

Attendance is recorded every week and is worth **20%** of your final grade

- 12 in-person meetings (Weeks 1-9, 11, 14, and 15), worth 10 points each

Everyone receives one automatic excused absence

- Documented medical or serious personal/family issues are also excused
- So are documented athletic conflicts (“Actual Missed Classes” in contracts)

Professional Conduct Policy

To receive attendance credit, you must follow the ***Professional Conduct Policy***

- Disruptive, rude, or otherwise unprofessional behavior will result in a loss of attendance credit
- Failing to follow the classroom technology policy also falls under this policy

Repeat violations face escalating deductions to your overall Attendance score

- 5% for 1st violation, additional 20%, 25%, and 50% for subsequent violations
- You will receive an email documenting the date and nature of each incident

R Coding Activities

The R coding activities are ***not graded*** and do not count towards your final grade

4 shorter-format activities introduced in class over the course of the semester

- Strongly recommended: they build skills you'll use for capstone data analysis
- Submit to Canvas by the posted due date and I will review your code and give you feedback

Capstone Papers

Overall objective of this course is doing your own economics research

- This means writing a capstone paper → 8-to-10-page research paper
- The capstone project overall is worth 40% of your final grade

The core of your capstone paper is your own independent data analysis

- Lectures are designed to give you the necessary tools to do this analysis
- Projects comprised of final presentation + paper + intermediate assignments

You may work individually or with a partner (both of you must do data analysis)

Late Assignment Submissions

Late capstone assignments receive a 10% reduction in total possible score for each day late

- After 7 days, unsubmitted assignments will **automatically** receive a score of 0
- I will **not** accept any assignments after this deadline

Teaching this class is extremely time- and labor-intensive

- Deadlines are set to ensure I have adequate time for instruction, course prep, etc.
- If you have questions about assignments, I am happy to help **before** they are due

After an assignment deadline has passed, it is your responsibility to submit it ASAP

- I will **not** respond to questions asking for detailed feedback, code review, etc. after the deadline for an assignment submission has passed

AI Policy

Some context: I use AI, I know students use AI, we will use AI in this class

Two overarching rules regarding AI:

- **All** written submissions for your capstone assignments must be ***in your own words***
- If you are ever unsure about how you're using AI, ask me ***before*** submission

If for ***any*** reason I suspect ***any*** of the writing for a capstone assignment was generated via an AI/LLM (or used with only light editing), I reserve the right to convert that assignment for that student into an in-person exam format

Doing Well in this Course

From prior semesters, students who did well tended to...

- #1 by far: show up to class
- Ask lots of questions & take advantage of office hours and email
- Stay on top of smaller assignments and not miss deadlines

My goal is for everyone to graduate!

- If you have questions, I am always happy to help

Goals for this Class

Two broad objectives (from the syllabus):

- Learn what modern (empirical) economics research looks like
- Learn how to conduct your own economic research

After this fall, you probably won't ever draw another graph by hand or take FOCs!

In practice, class is about getting comfortable working with & thinking about data

- This is what people think of when they see “BA in econ” on a resume
- Class assignments are designed to help you market yourself as an econ major

Getting Comfortable Working with Data

This class places a heavy emphasis on working with data

Goal is to give you **general** skills that are helpful in econ-related jobs

- We'll learn to use R...
- But most important topics are concepts like relationships, visualization, etc.

Ultimately, produce final projects that you can use to highlight skills on a resume, in an interview, etc.

Data-Related Jobs

As a student, I was always a bit wary when professors said their class was “useful”

- Professors work as professors... what about other jobs?
- I spend a lot of time thinking about generalizability for course content

When I talk about econ-related jobs as “using data” or being “data-adjacent,” I don’t just mean data science or academic research

This can include pricing strategy for Marriott (my wife), economic consulting (my brother), legislative analyst for CA’s state legislature (old classmate), etc.

Things to Do for Next Week

Tonight's in-class activity: get R and RStudio installed and running

Things to do this week:

- Coding Activity 1 — strongly recommended, not graded
- Review lecture material

Next week:

- Submit Coding Activity 1 to Canvas if you want feedback on it
- Lecture will start with a quick quiz on stats + R material from tonight

In general, anything on lecture slides or R activity is fair game for the quiz